The Littlest Hitler

By Ryan Boudinot

[I remember] the time I went as Hitler for Halloween. I had gotten the idea after watching World War II week on PBS. My dad helped me make the costume. I wore tan polyester pants and one of his khaki shirts, with sleeves so long they dragged on the floor unless I rolled them up. With some paints left over from when we made the pinewood derby car for YMCA Indian Guides, the painted a black swastika in a white circle on a red bandanna and tied it around my left arm. Using the Dippity-Do he put in his hair every morning, he gave my own hair that plastered, parted style that had made Hitler look as if he was always sweating. We clipped the sides off a fifty-cent mustache and adhered it to my upper lip with liquid latex. I tucked my pants into the black rubber boots I had to wear whenever I played outside and stood in front of the mirror. My dad laughed and said, "I guarantee it, Davy. You're going to be the scariest kid in the fourth grade."

INTRODUCTION

A child's understanding and comprehension of the atrocity known as The Holocaust is understandably limited. It is only with maturity, that the social concepts surrounding this time in history become clear. When one is 8 or 9, intellectual capacity often falls into the categories of good versus bad, black versus white, right versus wrong. In The Littlest Hitler by Ryan Boudinot we find a young boy just coming to terms with a concept which was at first beyond his grasp . . . . Hitler (scary Halloween costume or something more?)

My school had discouraged trick-or-treating since the razor blade and thumbtack incidents of 1982. Instead, they held the Harvest Carnival, not officially called "Halloween" so as not to upset the churchy types. Everyone at school knew the carnival was for wimps. All week before Halloween the kids had been separating themselves into two camps, those who got to go trick-or-treating and those who didn't. My dad was going

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to take me to the carnival, since I, like everybody else, secretly wanted to go. Then we'd go trick-or-treating afterward.

There were problems with my costume as soon as I got on the bus that morning. "Heil Hitlah!" the big kids in the back chanted until Mrs. Reese pulled over to reprimand them. We knew it was serious when she pulled over. The last pulling-over incident occurred when Carl Worthington cut off one of Ginger Lopez's pigtails with a pair of scissors stolen from the library.

"That isn't polite language appropriate for riding the bus!" Mrs. Reese said. "Do you talk like that around the dinner table? I want you both in the front seats, and as soon as we get to school I'm marching you to Mr. Warneke's office."

"But I didn't do anything!"

I felt guilty for causing the ruckus. Everybody was looking at me with these grim expressions. It's important, I suppose, to note that there wasn't a single Jewish person on the bus. Or in our school, for that matter. In fact, there was only one Jewish family in our town, the Friedlanders, and their kids didn't go to West Century Elementary because they were home-schooled freaks.

When I got to school Mrs. Thompson considered me for a moment in the doorway and seemed torn, both amused and disturbed at the implications of a fourth-grade Hitler. When she called roll I stood up sharply from my desk, did the salute I'd been practicing in front of the TV, and shouted, "Here!" Some people laughed.

After roll was taken we took out our spelling books, but Mrs. Thompson had other ideas. "Some of you might have noticed we have a historical figure in our class today. While the rest of you dressed up as goblins and fairies and witches, it looks like Davy is the only one who chose to come as a real-life person."

"I'm a real-life person, too, Mr. Thompson."

"And who would you be, Lisette?"

"I'm Anne Frank."

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Mrs. Thompson put a hand to her lips. Clearly she didn't know how to handle this. I'd never paid much attention to Lisette before. She'd always been one of the smart, pretty girls everyone likes. When I saw her rise from her desk with a lopsided Star of David made of yellow construction paper pinned to her Austrian-looking frock or whatever you call it, I felt the heat of her nine-year-old loathing pounding me in the face.

"This is quite interesting," Mrs. Thompson said. "You both came as figures from World War II. Maybe you can educate us about what you did. Davy, if you could tell us what you know about Hitler."

I cleared my throat. "He was a really, really mean guy."

"What made him so mean?"

"Well, he made a war and killed a bunch of people and made everybody think like him. He only ate vegetables, and his wife was his niece. He kept his blood in jars. Somebody tried to kill him with a suitcase, and then he took some poison and died."

"What people did he kill?"

"Everybody. He didn't like Jesse Owens because he as Afro-American."

"Yes, but mostly what kind of people did he have problems with?"

"He killed all the Jews."

"Not all Jews, fortunately, but millions of them. Including Anne Frank."

The classroom was riveted. I didn't know whether I was in trouble or what. Lisette smirked at me when Mrs. Thompson said her character's name, then walked to the front of the class to tell us about her.

"Anne Frank lived in Holland during World War II. And when the Nazis invaded she lived in someone's attic with her family and some other people. She wrote in her diary every day and liked movie stars. She wanted to grow up to write stories for a newspaper, but the Nazis got her and her family and made them go to a concentration camp and killed them. A concentration camp is a place where they burn people in ovens. Then somebody found her diary and everybody liked it."

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When Lisette was done everybody clapped. George Ford, who sat in front of me and was dressed as Mr. T. turned around, lowered his eyes, and shook his fist at me. "I pity the foo' who kills all the Jews."

Recess was a nightmare.

I was followed around the playground by Lisette's friends, who were playing horse with a jump rope, berating me for Anne Frank's death.

"How would you like it if you had to live in an attic and pee in a bucket and couldn't walk around or talk all day and didn't have much food to eat?"

It didn't take long for them to make me cry. The rule about recess was you couldn't go back into the building until the bell, so I had to wait before I could get out of my costume. I got knots in my stomach thinking about the parade at the end of the day. Everybody else seemed so happy in their costumes. And then Lisette started passing around a piece of notebook paper that said "We're on Anne Fran's Side," and all these people signed it. When my friend Charlie got the paper he tore it up and said to the girls, "Leave Davy alone! He just wanted to be a scary bad guy for Halloween and he didn't really kill anybody!"

"I should just go as someone else," I said, sitting beneath the slide while some kids pelted it with pea gravel. This was Charlie's and my fort for when we played GI Joe.

"They can kiss my grits," Charlie said. He was dressed as a deadly galactic robot with silver spray-painted cardboard tubes for arms and a pair of New Wave sunglasses. "This is a free country, ain't it? Hey! Stop throwing those son-of-a-bitching rocks!"

"Charlie!"

"Oops. Playground monitor. Time for warp speed." Charlie pulled on his thumb, made a clicking sound, and disappeared under the tire tunnel.

Despite Charlie's moral support, I peeled my mustache off and untied my armband as soon as I made it to the boys' room. There were three fifth-graders crammed into a

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stall, going, "Oh, man! There's corn in it!" None of them seemed to notice me whimpering by the sink.

Mrs. Thompson gave me her gray-haired wig to wear for the parade.

"Here, Davy. You can be an old ma. An old man who likes to wear khaki."

I knew Mrs. Thompson was trying to humor me and I resented her for it. Lisette, for whatever, reason, maybe because her popularity in our classroom bordered on celebrity worship, got to lead the parade. I was stuck between Beck Lewis and her pathetic cat outfit and Doug Becker, dressed as a garden. His mom and dad were artists. Each carrot, radish, and potato had been crafted in meticulous papier-mache, painted, lacquered, and halfway embedded in a wooden platform he wore around his waist. The platform represented a cross section, with brown corduroys painted with rocks and earthworms symbolizing dirt, and his fake-leaf-covered shirt playing the part of a trellis. For the third year in a row Doug ended up winning the costume contest.

By the time our parade made it to the middle school I was thoroughly demoralized. I had grown so weary of being asked, "What are you?" that I had taken to wearing the wig over my face and angrily answering, "I'm link! I'm lint!"

My dad made wood stoves for a living. When my mom left he converted our living room into a shop, which was embarrassing when my friends came over, because the inside of our house was always at least ninety degrees. My dad was genuinely disappointed when he learned of my classmates' reactions.

"But everyone knows you're not prejudiced. It's Halloween, for crying out loud." He folded the bandanna, looking sad and guilty. "I'm sorry, Davy. We didn't mean for it to turn out like this, did we? Tell you what. Let's go to Sprouse-Reitz and buy you the best goddamn costume they got."

We drove into town in the blue pickup we called Fleetwood Mack. Smooth like a Cadillac, built like a Mack truck. The Halloween aisle at 6:30 P.M. on October 31 is pretty slim pickings. There was a little girl with her mom fussing over a ballerina outfit – last-

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minute shoppers like us. I basically had a choice between a pig mask, some cruddy do-it-yourself face paint deals, and a discounted Frankenstein mask with a torn jaw.

"Hey! Lookit! Frankenstein!" my dad said, trying to invest some enthusiasm in the ordeal. "Don't worry about the jaw, we'll just duct tape it from the inside. Nobody'll even notice."

"I want a mask with real hair. Not fake plastic lumpy hair," I said.

"You don't really have a choice here, Davy. Unless you want the pig mask."

"Fine. I'll go as stupid Frankenstein."

My dad grabbed me by the elbow and spun me around. "Do you want a Halloween this year or not? You can't go trick-or-treating without a costume, and this is about your only option. Otherwise it's just you and me sitting on our [butts] in front of the television tonight."

In Fleetwood Mack we sang along to the Steve Miller Greatest Hits tape and picked the richest-looking neighborhoods to trick-or-treat on. With a greasy Burger King bag salvaged from the floor of the truck, we went door-to-door, my dad hanging out behind me, waving politely. Somebody even tossed him a can of beer.

I didn't know we were at the Friedlanders' house until Mrs. Friedlander opened the door. Word had it they were among the parents who didn't let their kids go trick-or-treating since the razor blade and thumbtack scare of 1982. Hannah Friedlander sat on the steps up to the second story of their split-level house, leaning over in her sorceress costume to see who it was. Mike, her brother, came up the stairs from the rec room and joined her, breathing dramatically in his Darth Vader mask. I wanted to do something nice for them, wanted to just hand them my whole bag, but I couldn't bring myself to do it. I'd be too embarrassed, I'd make my father angry, I'd call too much attention to the fact that they couldn't go trick-or-treating. SO I chose to do nothing but accept Mrs. Friedlander's individually wrapped Swiss chocolate balls and thanked her, then walked back to Fleetwood

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Mack with my dad and went home, looking at all the Halloween displays through the nostrils of Frankenstein's nose.

"So, did you have an okay Halloween after all?" my dad said, carrying me upstairs to my bedroom. I nodded and got into my PJs. He pulled the covers over my face and bit my nose through the blanket as he did every night. Later, when I could hear him snoring through the wall, I took the bag of candy from my dresser and tiptoed downstairs to what used to be our living room. There was a stove hooked up to each of our three chimneys, one which was cold, one with some embers inside, the third filled with flames. I opened the door to the flaming stove and thought about throwing my whole bag in there, but then remembered the rule: wood and paper only. Besides, I had an entire Snickers bar in there; I wasn't insane. I sat for a long time eating chocolates, one by one, in front of the fire. Then I reached into the stove to see how far I could go before it really started to hurt.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2005 National Qualifier

NOTE: Depending on the presentation of this selection, it could be either humorous or dramatic

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